52%

OF THE RESPONDENTS RATE RAHUL'S PERFORMANCE AS AN OPPOSITION LEADER AS GOOD OR OUTSTANDING

Bengaluru. If the Congress coined the term INDIA, Rahul insisted that Mamata propose the name. In response, she called him "our favourite", a sharp departure from her veiled criticism of his leadership in the past. Political experts say these U-turns are triggered by the existential crisis of non-BJP parties in electoral politics. PM Modi has already sounded the bugle by branding the 2024 Lok Sabha polls as a battle between the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) and parties which are "corrupt and dynastic". The proposal to call the alliance INDIA is an attempt to deny the BJP monopoly over nationalistic politics.

Whether it earns the Opposition parties electoral dividend or not, the INDIA nomenclature seems to have found resonance among the people. So, 39 per cent of the respondents think it is a catchy name and will fetch alliance partners votes. Another 30 per cent feel it is a catchy name but will not fetch votes. The assessment is not surprising as the electoral outcome will heavily depend on smart seat-sharing arrangements. Even after two meetings, there has been no word on a seat-sharing formula among the INDIA partners.

Non-Congress parties want the national party to focus on areas where it is involved in direct combat with the BJP and play the junior role in states like Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, Maharashtra, Jharkhand, Punjab and Delhi, an idea unacceptable to the state Congress units. The INDIA combine will have maximum electoral impact in these seven states that account for 244 seats in the 543-member Lok Sabha. Yet, there is a remote possibility of any joint fight by INDIA partners against the BJP in states like West Bengal. The Left has announced it will join hands with the TMC but the Congress state unit continues its potshots at Mamata.

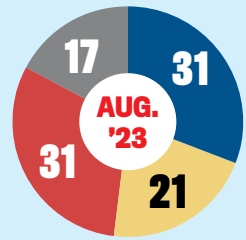
More importantly, in response to the INDIA alliance of 26 parties, the BJP has upgraded the NDA to showcase more muscle. It now has 38 partners. It's a different matter that of them, 25 do not have a single member in the current Lok Sabha. Of the 26 INDIA partners, 10 have no presence in the lower house. So, the battle between the NDA and INDIA, for the moment, remains restricted to political optics. That is the reason 54 per cent of the respondents feel INDIA cannot defeat the Modi-led BJP at the Centre. Only a superlative Congress performance can prove this lack of faith wrong as the eventual outcome will depend on what happens in he 186 Lok Sabha seats where the Congress and the BJP are directly pitted against each other. In 2019, the Congress won only 15 and that is where the challenge lies for Rahul and Kharge.

In a direct contest between Modi and Rahul, the Congress leader is still far behind as 52 per cent of the respondents say the incumbent is best suited to be the next prime minister. Only 16 per cent back Rahul, though he gains marginally—two percentage points—from January. But there is still some ray of hope for the Opposition parties.

In January, 46 per cent of the respondents said they got upset when Opposition leaders launched personal attacks on Modi. That has come down to 38 per cent in the current MOTN. The PM's popularity may still be head and shoulders above his competitors, but the voters are no more averse to seeing him being questioned. It is for the Opposition leaders now to ask the right questions and desist from indulging in a game of verbal one-upmanship. As the MOTN poll shows, whenever they have made the right noises, the people have taken note. ■

All figures in % and rounded off; DK/ CS (don't know/can't say)

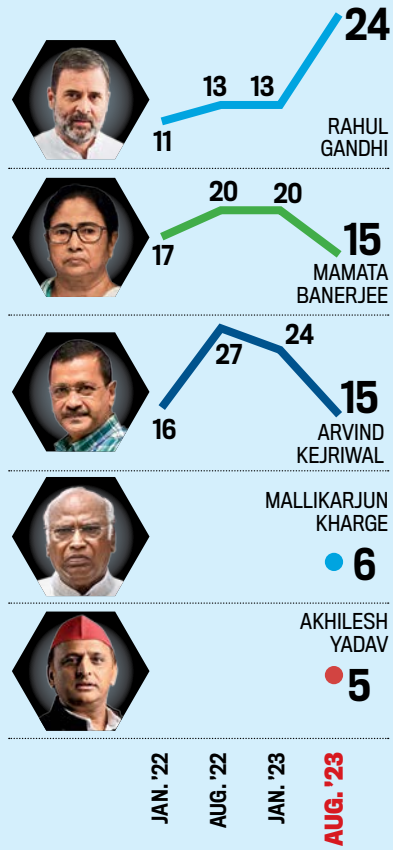
Q. What's your opinion on Rahul Gandhi's disqualification from Parliament?



It was a lawful and fair decision
The decision was lawful but too harsh
The decision was totally unlawful & politically motivated
DK/CS

Almost one-third call the move against Rahul totally unlawful and politically motivated

Q. Who, among the current Opposition leaders, is best suited to lead the Opposition alliance?



Rahul is most preferred to lead the Oppn alliance, has replaced Kejriwal since Jan.